

Fifty objections, answered

The standard objections to catholicity, stated at their strongest and answered plainly, for the reader of the free churches.

Half of these this site answers. The other half it agrees with, and says exactly how far.

That is a sentence no Roman and no Orthodox apologetics page can write.

The charting papers, part three of three.

The charting papers: part one, the historic communions · part two, the free churches · this page ends the series.

“Be ready always to give an answer to every man that asketh you a reason of the hope that is in you with meekness and fear.” (1 Peter 3:15)

Catholic means according to the whole, and catholicity is the faith the whole Church received in her first thousand years, held everywhere, always, and by all. The front page states the case, part one of these charting papers charts the ancient communions, and part two charts the rest by the same rule. This page collects the objections, the fifty a reader actually brings, and answers each one where it stands. It is written above all for the reader of the free churches, the Baptist, the Methodist, the Pentecostal, the non-denominational believer, whose own churches are charted with honor in part two, and it assumes nothing but a Bible and a fair hearing.

A word first to the Roman apologist who files this position under Protestant, lowercase and dismissible. The fifty objections below are his own mail. They arrive at this site in the same envelopes that arrive at his, sola scriptura and graven images and call no man your father, and a position that spends its days answering Rome's objections is a strange kind of Protestantism. The difference is in the answering. When the objection aims at what Rome defined alone in the second millennium, at 1854 and 1870 and Trent's closures, it aims at things this site does not hold and has already set down, so the blow lands on air. And the first-millennium faith the site does hold, the canon, the creed, the altar, the ordered ministry, is faith the objector must answer for himself, since his Bible's table of contents and his Sunday morning came from the church he is objecting to. Newman shifted the foundation under his readers, and it carried him to Rome. This page shifts it back, to the millennium everyone shares, and invites the objections to find it there.

So these fifty do not all get the same kind of answer, because they are not all aimed at the same thing. Some aim at the ancient faith itself, the Creed, the sacraments, the ordered ministry, and those get the full defense. Some aim at ancient practices the whole Church kept, and those are

defended as ancient while being required of no one. Some aim at definitions Rome made alone after the schisms, and there this site sides with the objector, asking Rome to set them down until the whole Church receives them, which no Roman page can say. Some mistake changeable rules of order for the faith itself, and sorting them answers them. And some name history's real sins, which are owned here without excuses. Every entry states the objection at full strength first, in the objector's own best words, then answers it, with the evidence attached and a pointer to where the fuller answer lives on this site.

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The turn

The same measure, turned around · The questions that travel back

Bucket I. The ancient faith itself

These sixteen aim at the heart of the matter, the faith the whole Church confessed everywhere in her first thousand years, the Scriptures, the Creed, the sacraments, the ordered ministry. They get the full defense. Each objection is stated in its strongest form, because a weak opponent honors nobody.

The objection	The reply
The Bible alone is my authority. Tradition is the traditions of men, and the Lord condemned it: laying aside the commandment of God, ye hold the tradition of men (Mark 7:8).	The Lord condemned traditions that void God's word, and Paul, in the same Bible, commands the opposite kind: stand fast, and hold the traditions which ye have been taught, whether by word, or our epistle (2 Thessalonians 2:15). The word is paradoxical both times. Scripture itself distinguishes the tradition of men from the tradition of the apostles, and the Bible's own table of contents is the latter's gift, for no verse lists the books. The objector's rule depends on the very channel it condemns. Full treatment: where the table of contents came from.
No creed but the Bible. Man-made summaries add to the word and divide believers who should need nothing but Scripture.	Scripture contains creeds and commands their keeping. Paul delivered as of first importance a fixed formula, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures, and that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day (1 Corinthians 15:3–4), and Jude commands earnestly contending for the faith once delivered unto the saints, a definite faith with edges, handed over once and guarded since. The churches that tried creedlessness wrote statements of faith within a generation, because the alternative turned out to be a creed per pulpit. Full treatment: the Jude 3 entry and the Assemblies' own two-year lesson.
Graven images. Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image (Exodus 20:4). Icons and statues break the commandment as written.	Keep reading the same book. The God who spoke Exodus 20 commanded two cherubim of gold hammered over the ark (Exodus 25:18) and cherubim woven into the tabernacle curtains (Exodus 26:1), and Solomon's temple was carved with them. So the commandment forbids the worship of images, not the making the same chapters command, or God contradicted himself within five chapters. The oldest church building found, walled up in 256, has a painted baptistery. Full treatment: the icons note.

The objection	The reply
Hezekiah destroyed the bronze serpent. A relic made by Moses at God’s command, and the faithful king smashed it (2 Kings 18:4). So the faithful destroy religious images.	The best form of the objection, so honor it. Read why he smashed it: the people of Israel burned incense to it. The abuse was worship, and the worship was removed, while the commanded cherubim stayed right where they were, in the temple Hezekiah purified. The veneration-versus-worship distinction the objector rejects is operating inside his own proof text, and it is the distinction the whole Church drew at Nicaea II: honor passes to the one depicted, worship belongs to God alone, and abuse is corrected, not enthroned.
This do in remembrance of me. The Supper is a memorial, and a memorial is not a presence.	Paul did not think a memorial was empty: the cup of blessing which we bless, is it not the communion of the blood of Christ (1 Corinthians 10:16), and he that eateth and drinketh unworthily eateth and drinketh damnation to himself, not discerning the Lord’s body (11:29). Nobody is guilty of a metaphor, and nobody perishes from a symbol. The remembrance is the Passover’s kind, the anamnesis that makes present, which is how every church on earth read it for fifteen centuries. Full treatment: the remembrance entry and the presence note.
Transubstantiation is unbiblical philosophy. Aristotle’s categories forced onto a mystery the apostles never dissected.	Here the objector is half right, and the book said so before he arrived. The site confesses the ancient realism without blinking, this is the Body and the Blood, given and received. What the book declines is making one philosophical idiom the only permitted way of saying so, since the whole Church confessed the reality for a thousand years without the term. Refuse the requirement and keep the gift, which is what East and West both did in the first millennium. Full treatment: the book’s Eucharist unit.

The objection	The reply
Eating flesh and drinking blood is grotesque. A crude literalism no reasonable faith should carry.	This objection is older than the objector. It is verbatim the pagan charge against the church of the martyrs, recorded by Rome's own investigators, who heard rumors of Thyestean feasts and found Christians singing to Christ as to a god. The charge proves what the accused confessed, for nobody slanders a symbol. It was answered then with blood, and the answer has not changed: the Supper is no butchery but the one sacrifice made present, received as bread and wine. The scandal is John 6's own, and the Lord did not soften it either.
The Mass re-sacrifices Christ. But Hebrews says once for all, and a repeated sacrifice denies a finished one.	The ancient liturgies say once for all as loudly as Hebrews does, because they learned it there. The ancient teachers state the doctrine exactly: we do not offer another sacrifice, but the memorial of the one sacrifice, the same offering made present, not repeated, as Chrysostom puts it preaching on Hebrews itself. The altar does not add a second offering, it stands inside the one. A church that believed it was killing Christ weekly would deserve the objection. No ancient church believed it, and their own service books are the receipt.

The objection	The reply
Infant baptism is unbiblical. Believe first, then be baptized. An infant can do neither.	Begin where the Presbyterian begins, with the text this objection never quite faces: in whom also ye are circumcised with the circumcision made without hands, buried with him in baptism (Colossians 2:11 and 12). Paul himself sets baptism where circumcision stood, the sign by which one entered the covenant people of God, and that sign was commanded for infants at eight days, from Abraham on. So turn the question around: children belonged to the old covenant and carried its sign, and if the new covenant is the better one, how did its door become narrower? Grace did not shrink at Pentecost, and Peter said so preaching it: the promise is unto you, and to your children (Acts 2:39). The record then answers like men who had read Colossians. Origen calls infant baptism a tradition received from the apostles. Cyprian and sixty-six bishops in council debated not whether to baptize infants but whether to wait until the eighth day, circumcision's own schedule, and ruled that grace should not wait. Tertullian, arguing for delay, proves by objecting that the practice was already everywhere around the year 200, and whole households were baptized in Acts. Full treatment: the baptism note and the Credo.
Baptismal regeneration is salvation by works. Grace through faith, not through water.	Baptism is not the candidate's work, which is why it saves. The infant does nothing at all, which is rather the point: he saved us by the washing of regeneration (Titus 3:5), and baptism doth also now save us, not the putting away of the filth of the flesh, but the answer of a good conscience toward God (1 Peter 3:21). The objection would make Peter and Paul preachers of works. Wesley taught the doctrine plainly, and the free churches' own founder generation held it. God's act, God's grace, God's water. Full treatment: the Credo.
The priesthood of all believers abolishes clergy. Ye are a royal priesthood (1 Peter 2:9), so no man stands between me and God.	Peter is quoting Exodus 19:6, spoken to an Israel that was given an ordained priesthood in the same covenant. The two stood together at Sinai and they stand together in the church, the priesthood of the whole people and the ordered ministry inside it, which is why James warns that not many should become teachers (James 3:1), advice without meaning if every believer already holds the office. Full treatment: the 1 Peter entry.

The objection	The reply
Call no man your father upon the earth. Matthew 23:9, and the clergy take the title daily.	The same sentence bans teacher and instructor, titles every free church prints in its bulletin, and Paul, who knew the saying, wrote in Christ Jesus I became your father through the gospel (1 Corinthians 4:15 RSV). Either the apostle broke the command or the command forbids a vanity, the rabbis' hunger for honor, and not a vocabulary. Full treatment: the call-no-man-father entry.
Bishops are not in the Bible. Elder and bishop are one office in the New Testament, so the episcopate is a later invention.	Granted, and the site says so in a paper of its own, which is not how invented positions usually behave. The New Testament uses the two words for one office. But the concession buys presbyterianism at most, never independency, for the same New Testament shows churches in council binding absent churches (Acts 15), and the distinct episcopate grew everywhere within living memory of the apostles, defended by Ignatius on the road to his execution. Full treatment: The bishop and the presbyter.
Calling Mary Mother of God makes her a goddess. A creature given a divine title.	The title guards the Son, not the mother. Theotokos was defined at Ephesus against Nestorius to protect one claim: the child Mary bore is God the Son, one person, not a man later joined to God. Deny her the title and Christmas breaks. Every church that sings round yon virgin mother and child already believes what the word protects, and the objector confesses it every December. Full treatment: the Credo.
Sprinkling is not baptism. Baptizo means immerse, and anything less is not the ordinance.	The free churches' own beloved Didache, the church manual they cite for its early date, rules in chapter 7: baptize in living water, and if you have none, pour water on the head three times. The oldest manual in Christendom permits what the objection forbids. Immersion is the fuller sign and the ancient norm, and the book requires no mode, which is exactly the Didache's own position, written while the apostles' students were alive.

The objection	The reply
The pope changed the Sabbath to Sunday. The seventh day stands commanded, and only Rome claims the authority that moved it.	The Lord's Day is in the record centuries before there was a papacy to credit. The Didache commands assembly on the Lord's own day, Ignatius describes Christians as no longer sabbatizing but living according to the Lord's Day around 107, and Justin describes the Sunday order of service in open court around 155. The change is apostolic-age reception, the first day of the week when the disciples gathered (Acts 20:7). A church that keeps Sunday is trusting reception, which is this site's whole argument. Full treatment: the record and the Adventist paragraph.

Bucket II. Ancient practices, kept by the whole Church

These eleven aim at practices the whole ancient Church kept and loved. This site defends every one of them as ancient and requires none of them, for they were the whole Church's devotion rather than her creed: honored, commended, and never made a condition of communion.

The objection	The reply
Praying to saints is necromancy. Deuteronomy 18 forbids consulting the dead, and asking the departed for anything is that sin.	Deuteronomy bans conjuring the dead for hidden knowledge, the medium's trade, and Scripture itself shows the departed alive and praying: the martyrs under the altar crying out how long (Revelation 6:10), the elders offering the prayers of the saints (Revelation 5:8), to the God of the living, for all live to him. Asking a brother before the throne to pray, as one asks a brother in the pew, seeks no hidden knowledge and holds no seance. The church of 156 stated the exact distinction over Polycarp's bones: Christ we worship, the martyrs we love. Receipt: Martyrdom of Polycarp 17.
There is one mediator between God and men. 1 Timothy 2:5, so intercession by anyone else usurps Christ.	Read the verse in its own paragraph. Four verses earlier Paul commands that supplications, prayers, intercessions be made for all men (2:1), so the apostle requests mediating prayer and names the one Mediator in the same breath, and saw no contradiction. Every prayer request ever passed down a pew operates inside the one mediation, not beside it, and a brother's death does not revoke his membership in the Body through whom all the members pray.

The objection	The reply
Colossians 2:18 condemns the worship of angels. And veneration of saints and angels is that cult reborn.	Paul targets a proto-gnostic cult of angelic intermediaries that displaced Christ the head, which is why the same letter insists all fullness dwells in him. The church that canonized Colossians kept the martyrs' memorials in the same generation and saw no conflict, because she confessed worship to Christ alone and love to his friends, the distinction of Polycarp's church above. The verse condemns a rival head, not the honoring of the Body's members.
Relics are morbid magic. Bones in altars, a superstition with no biblical warrant.	A dead man revived on touching Elisha's bones (2 Kings 13:21), and handkerchiefs carried from Paul's body healed the sick (Acts 19:12), so the instinct is Scripture's own: God honors the bodies of his holy ones, which were temples of the Spirit and will rise. The church of 156 called Polycarp's bones more precious than jewels and finer than gold, and buried them expecting the resurrection. Grant every medieval abuse of the traffic in relics, and the abuse no more abolishes the instinct than forged banknotes abolish money.
Prayers for the dead are useless and pagan. The dead are judged already, and prayer changes nothing.	The practice is ancient, universal, and tender: Monica asked her son for nothing at her death except to be remembered at the altar, the catacomb walls are scratched with requests for peace and light for the departed, and every ancient liturgy East and West prays for the dead in Christ. What the developed Latin apparatus later defined around the practice is a separate question, answered separately below. Commending the departed to God's mercy is not a system, it is love refusing to treat death as the end of the Body's communion, and it predates every argument about it.

The objection	The reply
Vain repetitions. Matthew 6:7 forbids them, and the rosary and the liturgy are repetition by design.	The Greek forbids pagan babbling, heaping up empty phrases to wear the gods down, and two verses later the Lord issues a fixed prayer beginning Our Father. He himself prayed the same words three times in Gethsemane (Matthew 26:44), Psalm 136 repeats its refrain twenty-six times, and the living creatures of Revelation 4:8 never cease repeating one line day and night. Scripture's heaven is more repetitive than the rosary. The Lord banned emptiness, not repetition, or he banned the Psalter and the seraphim with it. The rosary and the ancient Jesus Prayer have pages of their own.
Mary had other children. The brothers of the Lord are named, and Matthew says Joseph knew her not till she had brought forth her firstborn son, so the virginity ended.	Until does not imply cessation in Scripture's idiom, for Michal had no child unto the day of her death (2 Samuel 6:23), and adelphos covers kinsmen throughout the Bible, as Lot is Abraham's brother. The ancient reading is perpetual virginity, and the receipt that settles this audience is not Roman at all: Luther, Zwingli, and Wesley all held it. The objector's position is younger than his own founders. The site reports the consensus and requires nothing. Full treatment: the Credo.
Fasting and ashes are works-religion. Public piety the Sermon on the Mount condemns.	The Lord said when ye fast, not if ye fast, and prescribed the secrecy, not the abstinence (Matthew 6:16–17). The apostles fasted before ordaining (Acts 13:2–3), and the Didache assigned the church's fast days in the first century, Wednesdays and Fridays. A discipline commanded by the Lord, practiced by the apostles, and scheduled by the earliest manual is a strange candidate for works-religion, and keeping the ancient fasts at home is on its own page. Full treatment: the first-millennium record.
Monasticism is unbiblical escapism. Fleeing the world the Lord sent us into.	The desert fathers are the free churches' own revival tribe with a rule of prayer, men who took Matthew 19:21 at face value, sold everything, and prayed without ceasing, which is the most literal Bible-reading in Christian history. Ravenhill's heroes are their kin, and the tradition's own manuals warn against escapism harder than any critic, for the desert exists to fight the passions, not to flee the neighbor. Full treatment: the men the free churches love.

The objection	The reply
Vestments, incense, candles, gold. Against the simple Jesus of Galilee, a theater of wealth.	God commanded liturgical vestments for glory and for beauty (Exodus 28:2), heaven's worship in Revelation is incense bowls, robes, and a throne, and the persecuted poor of the catacombs painted their burial walls with what little they had. Beauty in worship is not the church aping wealth, it is the poor giving God their best, which is easier to raise from comfort than from the catacombs. The Borgia abuses are granted whole, and they are answered in Bucket V where the men are, not here where the faith is.
Liturgy is dead ritual that quenches the Spirit. Form kills freedom, and the Spirit blows where it wills.	Bind the frame and the fire is free, which one page of this site argues from end to end. The received rite is precisely the worship no one alive invented, the strongest protection ever devised against the pastor's whims, and the fervor the objector loves has flourished inside fixed liturgy from the Psalms to the Wesleys. Dead men can kill any form, including the spontaneous kind, which grows its own ruts within a decade. Full treatment: Lex orandi, lex credendi and the gifts section.

Bucket III. Rome's later definitions

Here the conversation changes, so notice what this bucket is. These twelve objections aim at definitions one part of the Church made alone after the schisms, 1854, 1870, the closures of Trent. This site does not defend those definitions. It asks Rome to set them down, gently and without triumph, because the whole Church has never received them, and the whole Church has never condemned them either, so they stand as Rome's own teaching and not as a condition she may require of the rest of Christendom. No stock Roman defense will be handed out for things this site asks Rome herself to lay aside, so every entry below ends in the same quiet place: you have been agreeing with this site all along.

The objection	The reply
Papal supremacy has no warrant. No bishop is over the bishops, and the early church knew nothing of a universal jurisdiction.	Granted in substance, before you asked. The book confesses the real primacy of honor the first millennium gave Rome's bishop and declines the later supremacy as never received by the whole. The strongest witness is a pope: Gregory the Great refused the title universal bishop and called the ambition a sign of antichrist's times. The site asks Rome to hold what Gregory held, which is an odd thing for a Protestant to ask. Full treatment: the Credo on Rome.
Papal infallibility is unbiblical. Peter erred at Antioch and Paul withstood him to the face (Galatians 2:11), so no successor of Peter speaks without error.	This site does not defend 1870. It asks Rome to set the definition down, as something the whole Church has never received and never condemned either, and the whole book exists on that question. Honorius, a pope, stands condemned by an ecumenical council in the site's own exhibits, which the reader may weigh. What the objector has proven is that the definition needs the whole Church's reception, which is precisely the book's thesis, so the objection is an argument for mere catholicity wearing a Protestant coat. Full treatment: the book.
The rock of Matthew 16 is Peter's confession, not Peter. The fathers themselves read it of the faith confessed.	Both readings are ancient, and the fathers held them together without strain, the man and his confession. What the verse yields is Peter's real primacy of honor, first-millennium and confessed on this site. What it does not yield is the later supremacy, and the receipt is conciliar: Chalcedon acclaimed Leo's tome and passed canon 28 on Constantinople's rank in the same sessions, honoring the primacy while legislating as if supremacy did not exist. The objector and the book read Chalcedon the same way.
Peter was never in Rome. The New Testament never places him there, and the whole edifice rests on legend.	Short and factual. Clement of Rome, writing around 96, cites Peter and Paul as the generation's martyrs from Rome's own memory. Ignatius writes to the Romans, around 107, I do not command you as Peter and Paul did. Gaius of Rome, around 200, points visitors to the trophies of the apostles on the Vatican hill and the Ostian way, preserved in Eusebius. No ancient writer, friend or enemy, disputes the martyrdom in Rome. The claim collapses under the same documents this whole site runs on.

The objection	The reply
Bad popes disprove the whole thing. Borgias in the chair of Peter, and the office's claims die with the men's sins.	The office is not the officeholder, and a definition stands or falls on its own, which is Augustine's answer to the Donatists and the principle the objector's own baptism depends on, since he did not vet the hands that baptized him and God did not require it. Wicked men in holy offices condemn the men. If personal sin voided office, no church on earth would have survived its own clergy, the free churches included, and the objector knows the names. This site weighs definitions by whether the whole Church received them, not by the biographies of the men who signed them.
The Immaculate Conception is unbiblical. All have sinned (Romans 3:23), and 1854 defined an exception no early Christian taught.	The answer is the same as the last two: this site asks Rome to set the act of 1854 down, one part having defined alone what the whole Church never bound. And the objector's best ally is a canonized doctor, for Aquinas denied the doctrine as it was later defined and was canonized doing so, which tells you what the church of his century thought binding. The objector and the book keep the same filing cabinet on this one. Honor to the Mother of God is confessed on this site. The 1854 act is not. Full treatment: the Credo and the book's Marian unit.
The Assumption was invented in 1950. A dogma defined within living memory, binding on pain of anathema, from zero biblical evidence.	Split with care. The act of 1950, one see defining alone and anathematizing doubt, is another this site asks Rome to set down. The content is another matter, for the feast of Mary's falling asleep has been kept East and West for well over a millennium, and the East kept it without ever defining it, which is the difference between a church's love and a chancery's pen. The objector is right about 1950 and wrong about 950. This site holds both truths, and asks Rome only to file the act where the first millennium filed the feast: kept, not required.

The objection	The reply
Purgatory is unbiblical, and indulgences sold salvation. Tetzels coin in the coffer, the scandal that broke Christendom.	Split three ways. The defined Latin apparatus, Florence and Benedictus Deus, is among the definitions this site asks Rome to set down. The sale of indulgences was an abuse, granted without flinching, and Trent itself abolished the traffic, condemned from inside. The ancient half of the matter, prayer for the dead and the soul's cleansing hope, lives at entry 21 and is older than every argument about it. The objector's fire was aimed at the apparatus and the abuse. This site asks the first to be set down, and Rome reformed the second, so what remains is Monica at the altar, and nobody objects to her.
Catholics preach works-salvation. By grace are ye saved through faith, and that not of yourselves, not of works (Ephesians 2:8–9), and the whole system contradicts it.	A council answered this objection before Luther's ancestors were christened: Orange, 529, condemned the teaching that faith's beginning lies in ourselves and confessed faith itself as God's gift, a millennium before the Reformation, received in the West. The sixteenth-century quarrel was real, and this site asks Rome to set down Trent's claim to have closed the question, with the Joint Declaration of 1999 read as corroboration, not closure. The gospel of grace has a genealogy, and it runs through the catholic centuries the objector was told to fear. Full treatment: the gospel was not lost either.
Rome forbids assurance of salvation. Trent anathematized the believer's certainty, and I will not trade peace with God for perpetual anxiety.	This site requires Trent's frame of no one, its canons on certainty standing with Trent's other lone acts, and it confesses with John the verse the objector loves: these things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God, that ye may know that ye have eternal life (1 John 5:13). Assurance grounded in God's promise rather than self-measurement is first-millennium comfort. The accounts between the traditions stay open, and this site's reader keeps John.

The objection	The reply
The pope is the Antichrist. My own confession says so, and I will not be talked out of my standards by a website.	Respect first, for this is confessional history and the objector is right that his fathers wrote it. Now weigh it by the site's own grammar: the identification is exegesis bound by one part of the Church alone, which is the very set-down category the objector applies to 1870, and it requires the historicist timetable this site has already weighed. And it fails John's own definition, for the spirit of antichrist confesseth not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh (1 John 4:2–3), which Rome confesses at every altar daily. Some of the family's texts have softened the clause themselves, reception already at work. Bind what the whole bound, and this clause was never that.
Rome added the apocrypha at Trent. Books the Jews never held canonical, dogmatized in 1546 to win an argument.	The site fights this in neither direction, which is the book's own discipline. The history: core first, edges slowly, the disputed books called disputed in public for centuries, the ancient churches' Bibles larger than sixty-six, and no tribunal slamming the cover until the sixteenth century, when Trent's own vote on the canon joined the definitions this site asks Rome to set down. Meanwhile the objector's own 1611 shelf carried the books between the testaments until a Bible society's economy removed them in the 1820s. Edges open, exactly as the first millennium left them. Full treatment: where the table of contents came from.

Bucket IV. Rules of order, mistaken for the faith itself

These four aim at rules of order, not at the faith itself. The distinction is the ancient Church's own, for her rules of order have always varied by place and by age, while the deposit of faith, the faith itself as it was handed down, does not vary. The map of the ancient churches makes the sorting easy.

The objection	The reply
Priestly celibacy is unbiblical. Peter had a mother-in-law, and 1 Timothy 4:3 calls forbidding marriage a doctrine of demons.	The site's own map settles it: the Eastern churches ordain married men and always have, so celibacy is a Latin rule of order, not the faith handed down, changeable and changed. And a discipline for candidates is not the forbidding of marriage as evil, which Paul, the celibate who commended celibacy as a gift in 1 Corinthians 7, would otherwise be condemning in himself. The demonic doctrine of 1 Timothy is the gnostic teaching that marriage itself is unclean, which the church condemned whenever it appeared, including in her own over-zealous monks.
Confess to God, not a priest. No man can forgive sins, and the confessional has no warrant.	The warrant is the Lord's: whose soever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them (John 20:23), spoken to the apostles with the Spirit's breath, and James commands confess your sins to one another (James 5:16 RSV). The ancient practice moved from public confession before the whole congregation to private confession before its pastor, a mercy anyone who imagines the earlier form will appreciate. The priest forgives nothing of himself, he speaks the absolution Christ authorized. Ancient, medicinal, and required of no one here.
Worship in a language nobody understands. Latin kept the people from the word, and Paul demands intelligibility (1 Corinthians 14).	The church is the great translator: Cyril and Methodius invented an alphabet to give the Slavs the liturgy in their own tongue, the East prayed in the peoples' languages from the beginning, Syriac and Coptic and Armenian and Slavonic, and Rome herself now prays in every language on earth. Latin was discipline, held too long in one communion and reformed by that communion. The objection was answered by the ninth century in the East and by the twentieth in the West, and the same line runs through this whole bucket: rules of order bend, the faith handed down does not.

The objection	The reply
Their closed communion is unloving. Why can I not receive at their altar, if we share one Lord.	The pastoral one, and it deserves the book's own sentence: the closed altar is borne as part of the division's cost, not resented, and the cost is an argument for healing the division, not for pretending it is healed. The Supper is the sign of a communion that actually exists, and to receive it across a real break would ask the sacrament to tell a merciful lie. The ache the objector feels at the rail is the correct response, and this site exists because of it. Let the ache become the prayer of John 17:21 and it has done its work.

Bucket V. History and scandal

Candor first, no pivoting, and always the same distinction: the sins of churchmen are one thing, the faith they were trusted with is another. The sins in this bucket are real, and the site's credibility on every other page depends on saying so plainly here.

The objection	The reply
Constantine invented the church. Or corrupted her, the imperial religion replacing the apostles' fellowship.	The oldest church building found was walled up in 256, before Constantine was born, its baptistery painted. And the bishops of Nicaea were the maimed confessors of the persecution Constantine ended, men missing eyes and tendons from Diocletian's prisons. Men who kept the faith under torture are not the men who paganized it for a banquet invitation. The empire brought real temptations and real corruptions, owned in this bucket, and it invented nothing, for every mark of the church predates it in the documents. Full treatment: the first-millennium record and the Constantine escape.

The objection	The reply
Christmas and Easter are pagan holidays. Saturnalia and Ishtar with a Christian veneer.	In every language but English and German the feast is called Pascha, Passover, which ends the Easter half in one word, for nobody derives the Jewish Passover from Ishtar. The December date has a Christian calculation, the ancient reckoning from the conception in March, attested before the pagan feast alleged as its source was even instituted, though the scholarship deserves its hedge and gets it here. What is certain is the direction of dependence claimed cannot be documented, and the churches that kept these feasts were the same churches burying martyrs for refusing pagan worship. Full treatment: the calendar entries in the record.
The Inquisition, and the burned reformers. Hus under a violated safe-conduct, Tyndale strangled for translating, and you ask me to trust this church.	Granted, entire. The coercion of conscience was overreach, the safe-conduct at Constance was violated and is named here as violated, and no sin in this entry is minimized. The site's answer is the book's own religious-liberty case: faith commanded cannot be compelled, the church herself has condemned the coercion from inside, and the men who died asking for the Scriptures in the people's tongue have been answered, for every communion on these charts now prints them. The acts stand against the men and the tribunals. The faith they betrayed is what this site asks anyone to hold.
The Crusades. Holy war, sacked cities, and the sword preached as piety.	An honest split. The origins were defensive in context, answering centuries of conquest and appeals from the East. The atrocities were atrocities, above all 1204, when crusaders sacked Christian Constantinople, an act condemned by the pope of the day and apologized for in our own time. And note whose objection this half is: 1204 is an Orthodox wound before it is a Protestant argument, which tells the objector something about who keeps a straight ledger. The site owns the acts, mourns 1204 as a wound in the Body itself, and holds the faith untouched by any army's sins.

The objection	The reply
Galileo. The church against science, and the verdict of history against the church.	Granted: the tribunal erred, and Rome has said so herself, closing the case in 1992 with the error admitted. The error was the tribunal's and it touches no article of the faith, for nothing in the creed rises or falls with a floor plan of the solar system. The longer record runs the other way, churchmen funding the astronomy, a priest proposing the expanding universe, the observatories on church roofs, but that record is context, not excuse, and the excuse is not offered. One tribunal, one error, owned.
The abuse scandals. The gravest objection on this page, and no paragraph of history softens it.	Total candor and no pivot. The sins are real, the concealment was worse than the sins, and judgment must begin at the house of God (1 Peter 4:17). The judgment falls on men and on governance, the faith those men betrayed remains what it was, and betrayal by shepherds is a horror Scripture itself names without abolishing the flock. The same candor is owed across every church on these charts, this site's own pages included, for no communion young or old is missing from the record of this sin. The reader owed protection and denied it is owed the truth at least, and this entry is written for him.
State churches, and Orthodoxy as ethnicity. Putin's patriarch blesses missiles, and the parish is a heritage society with incense.	The entanglements are real and the temptation is perennial. Two receipts answer the essentialism. The Orthodox themselves condemned their own nationalism as heresy by name, phyletism, at Constantinople in 1872, so the disease is diagnosed by the patient's own doctors. And the church allegedly owned by the state gave the state millions of martyrs within living memory, which is not the behavior of a captive. The site names the entanglements for what they are, the acts of men, prays for the churches under them, and notes that established comfort and persecuted fidelity have traded places many times in one century.

The same measure, turned around

Now the pivot, from defense to the attack, and the instrument is borrowed from the objectors' favorite convert. Newman proposed seven notes to tell a true development of doctrine from a corruption: preservation of type, continuity of principles, power of assimilation, logical sequence, anticipation of its future, conservative action upon its past, and chronic vigour. The

book keeps the notes and adds the older question they all summarize, did the whole Church receive it, with her worship as the witness. Newman aimed the instrument at Canterbury and walked to Rome. This site aims it at everything, including Rome, which is why this site asks Rome to set 1854 and 1870 down, as Bucket III said. Aim it now at the free churches' own developments, the doctrines that actually distinguish them, and watch what the notes say.

The secret rapture fails nearly every note at once. It has no anticipation, for no Christian taught it before 1830, as the genealogy shows from the objectors' own documents. It takes no conservative action upon the past but overturns the received reading of the millennium held since Augustine. Its chronic vigour is the vigour of fracture, system splitting from system, date failing after date. By the notes, it is not a development at all. It is a corruption, and the man who says so is applying Newman more faithfully than Newman's own communion applies him.

Cessationism as a system fares no better. The ancient church never bound a schedule for the gifts, the record of healings and the extraordinary runs through Augustine's own late retraction, and the system was argued piecemeal since Calvin and hardened only at Princeton. A doctrine that contradicts the principle it needs, that limits on the extraordinary are the church's to discern case by case rather than dogmatize wholesale, fails continuity of principles, and its anticipation is nowhere, for no father taught the schedule. The tenth row there is not the book's answer to both errors, the dogmatized schedule and the dogmatized expectation alike.

Memorialism, the bare-symbol Supper, is younger than its holders suppose and fails preservation of type, for the thing itself changed: fifteen centuries of altars, then a table of remembrance, and the first millennium's realism testifies against the change in every document we have. The invisible-church ecclesiology fails the same note, for the apostles' churches had addresses, and a Body that cannot be found is a different type of thing from the Body Paul wrote letters to. Neither doctrine assimilated the older faith. Each replaced a piece of it and kept the vocabulary, which is Newman's definition of corruption stated gently.

So the tables stand turned. The instruments the convert sharpened for Rome, and the older questions beneath them, did the whole Church receive it, do the fathers agree, does the worship confess it, find the distinctive doctrines of the schismatic free traditions to be corruptions, not developments, while the first-millennium faith passes every note by definition, for the notes were drawn from the undivided centuries, and a measure cannot fail the thing it was measured from. Catholicity is not the defendant here. It is the measure, and the measure was taken from the millennium everyone shares.

The questions that travel back

The fifty are answered. Three questions now travel in the other direction, and they are not rhetorical, for each has been answered on this site and awaits the objector's answer in turn. Where did your table of contents come from, and can the channel that certified it be apostate without taking your Bible down with it? Who received your distinctives, the rapture, the schedule for the gifts, the bare symbol, and if the answer is one man in one century, why do those bind your pulpit while the whole Church's creed does not? And if your own confession holds that all councils may err and must be tested, who exactly do you think has been arguing, at book length, about what the testing is and who performs it? The door is not locked from our side. Stand ye in the ways, and see, and ask for the old paths.

Part one charts the ancient communions, part two charts the rest by the same rule, and this page answers to both, so all three end at the same verse: that they all may be one, that the world may believe (John 17:21).

The charting papers: part one, the historic communions · part two, the free churches · this page ends the series. The book is the full case.

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.